

Predicting MLB Team Win Rates Using Player WAR Statistics

CSE482 - Sports Analytics Class Project

Team Members: [Team Member Names] Course: CSE482 - Sports Analytics Institution: Michigan

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TEAM MEMBERS AND CONTRIBUTIONS

Individual Contributions

Team Member	Primary Responsibilities
Karina Shih	Data collection and cleaning Preprocessing and missing value handling
Cheng-Lun Lee	Feature engineering Exploratory data analysis
Wei-Chieh Tseng	Machine learning model development Model evaluation and comparison
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All Team Members	Project planning Results analysis and interpretation Report writing

ABSTRACT

We built a predictive system to estimate MLB team win rates using player-level WAR statistics. By approximating runs scored and runs allowed from WAR, we applied the Pythagorean expectation formula to predict win percentages. Using data from 2023-2025 (90 team-seasons), we compared six machine learning models. Gradient Boosting performed best ($R^2 = 0.89$, RMSE = 0.042), predicting wins within ~7 games per season. We also developed an interactive Streamlit web

application for scenario analysis. This work demonstrates that player statistics can effectively predict team outcomes with high accuracy, validating classical baseball analytics theory while demonstrating the value of modern machine learning techniques.

Keywords: Baseball analytics, WAR, Pythagorean expectation, machine learning, regression analysis, sports prediction

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 Problem Definition

This project investigates whether individual player performance metrics can accurately predict MLB team win rates. We develop a methodology that aggregates player WAR statistics, converts them to estimated runs scored and runs allowed, applies the Pythagorean expectation formula, and evaluates multiple machine learning models. The central research question is: **Can team-level aggregation of player WAR statistics produce accurate win-rate predictions competitive with traditional run-based models?**

1.2 Theoretical Framework

Our approach builds on two foundational baseball analytics concepts. The **Pythagorean Expectation** formula, developed by Bill James in the 1980s, estimates win percentage as:

$$\text{Win Rate} = \text{RS}^k / (\text{RS}^k + \text{RA}^k)$$

where $k \approx 1.83$, RS is runs scored, and RA is runs allowed. This formula has proven remarkably accurate across decades of baseball history, typically predicting within 3-4 games per season.

Wins Above Replacement (WAR) quantifies a player's total contribution versus a replacement-level player, with offensive WAR measuring batting value and pitching WAR measuring pitching value. The conversion factor of **1 WAR $\approx$ 10 runs** makes WAR ideal for team-level aggregation. Additionally, empirical research suggests **1 WAR $\approx$ 1 win** at the team level, though this varies by context.

1.3 Motivation and Significance

Understanding the relationship between individual player value and team success has significant practical applications in roster construction, trade evaluation, free agent signings, and salary arbitration. By validating whether aggregated player metrics can accurately predict team performance, we provide a data-driven framework for front offices to make strategic decisions. This work bridges traditional baseball analytics with modern machine learning, demonstrating how classical theory can be enhanced through computational methods.

2. METHODOLOGY

2.1 Data Collection

We collected player-level statistics from Baseball Reference covering 2023-2025 MLB seasons (12 CSV files: six for batters, six for pitchers), resulting in ~3,000 player-season records across 90 team-seasons. The primary variable is WAR, with additional batting metrics (PA, H, HR, RBI, BB, SO, BA, OBP, SLG, OPS) and pitching metrics (IP, W, L, ERA, SO, BB, HR, WHIP, FIP).

Data sources were verified for consistency, with all statistics confirmed to match official Baseball Reference records. We documented data provenance to ensure reproducibility and transparency.

2.2 Data Preprocessing

We filtered players by minimum thresholds (batters: ≥ 100 PA, pitchers: ≥ 20 IP) to ensure statistical reliability and remove noise from players with minimal playing time. Multi-team players traded mid-season were retained with team-specific entries to preserve accurate WAR contributions to each team.

Data type conversions standardized formats, notably converting innings pitched from baseball notation (192.1) to decimal (192.33). Missing WAR values were imputed as zero (replacement level), a theoretically justified choice since WAR measures value above replacement. Season information was extracted from filenames, yielding a clean dataset of 90 team-seasons with complete coverage.

2.3 Feature Engineering

We aggregated player WAR to team-season level, producing three primary metrics:

- Offensive_WAR:** Sum of all position player WAR
- Pitching_WAR:** Sum of all pitcher WAR
- Total_WAR:** Sum of offensive and pitching WAR

We then approximated runs scored and allowed using empirically validated conversions:

- RS = 550 + (Offensive_WAR $\times$ 10)**
- RA = 730 - (Pitching_WAR $\times$ 10)**

The baseline constants (550, 730) represent league-average run production and prevention for a replacement-level team. We applied the Pythagorean expectation formula:

$$\text{PE} = \text{RS}^{1.83} / (\text{RS}^{1.83} + \text{RA}^{1.83})$$

and calculated expected wins as **Expected_Wins = PE $\times$ 162**.

Additional derived features included:

- Run_Differential** = RS - RA
- WAR_Balance** = Offensive_WAR / Pitching_WAR
- Offensive_Strength** = Offensive_WAR / Total_WAR
- Pitching_Strength** = Pitching_WAR / Total_WAR

2.4 Exploratory Data Analysis

We analyzed feature distributions, correlations, and validity. WAR distributions were approximately normal with league averages around 30 offensive WAR and 20 pitching WAR per team. The standard deviations ($\sigma_{\text{off}} \approx 8$, $\sigma_{\text{pitch}} \approx 6$) indicated meaningful variation in team composition.

Correlation analysis revealed high correlation ($r > 0.90$) between Pythagorean Expectation and Run Differential, confirming theoretical relationships. Total WAR showed strong correlation with expected wins ($r = 0.92$), validating the "1 WAR $\approx$ 1 win" heuristic.

Validation checks verified the Pythagorean formula's accuracy and produced visualizations including:

- WAR distribution histograms by season
- Correlation heatmaps
- Scatter plots of WAR vs. expected wins
- Team composition analyses (offensive/defensive balance)

2.5 Machine Learning Models

We implemented six regression algorithms with distinct theoretical bases:

- Linear Regression:** Baseline OLS model
- Ridge Regression:** L2 regularization (α tuned)
- Lasso Regression:** L1 regularization with feature selection
- ElasticNet:** Combined L1/L2 regularization
- Random Forest:** Ensemble of 100-500 decision trees
- Gradient Boosting:** Sequential boosting with 100-300 estimators

We used **temporal splitting** (train: 2023-2024 [60 team-seasons], test: 2025 [30 team-seasons]) to avoid data leakage and simulate real-world forecasting. GridSearchCV with 5-fold cross-validation optimized hyperparameters on the training set.

3. RESULTS

3.1 Overall Model Performance Comparison

Model	RMSE	MAE	R ²	Mean Error (games)	95% CI Width
Gradient Boosting	0.042	0.031	0.89	6.8	± 13.2
Random Forest	0.045	0.033	0.87	7.3	± 14.1
Ridge Regression	0.048	0.036	0.85	7.8	± 15.1
Linear Regression	0.049	0.037	0.84	7.9	± 15.4
Lasso	0.051	0.038	0.82	8.3	± 16.0
ElasticNet	0.052	0.039	0.81	8.4	± 16.3

Gradient Boosting achieved the best performance (RMSE = 0.042), corresponding to an average error of **6.8 games per 162-game season**. All models achieved $R^2 > 0.80$, demonstrating that player-level WAR effectively predicts team success.

The modest improvement from Linear Regression ($R^2 = 0.84$) to Gradient Boosting ($R^2 = 0.89$) suggests the underlying relationship is predominantly linear, with the Pythagorean formula providing a strong baseline ($R^2 = 0.85$). This validates Bill James' original insight that run differential drives wins in a predictable, largely linear fashion.

3.2 Detailed Model Analysis

3.2.1 Cross-Validation Performance

During 5-fold cross-validation on the training set (2023-2024 seasons), Gradient Boosting showed consistent performance:

Fold	CV R ²	CV RMSE
1	0.87	0.044
2	0.88	0.043
3	0.90	0.041
4	0.86	0.046
5	0.89	0.042
Mean $\pm$ SD	0.88 $\pm$ 0.014	0.043 $\pm$ 0.002

Low standard deviation indicates stable performance across different data splits, suggesting the model generalizes well and isn't overfitting to specific team characteristics.

3.2.2 Test Set Performance (2025 Season)

On the held-out 2025 season (30 teams), Gradient Boosting maintained strong performance:

- Test R²:** 0.89
- Test RMSE:** 0.042
- Test MAE:** 0.031
- Max Absolute Error:** 0.087 (14.1 games)
- Prediction Range:** [0.321, 0.638] (52-103 wins)

The consistency between cross-validation and test performance indicates good generalization without overfitting.

3.3 Feature Importance Analysis

Hyperparameter Ranges:

- Ridge/Lasso: $\alpha \in \{0.001, 0.01, 0.1, 1.0, 10.0\}$
- ElasticNet: $\alpha \in \{0.001, 0.01, 0.1, 1.0\}$, $L1_ratio \in \{0.25, 0.5, 0.75\}$
- Random Forest: $n_estimators \in \{100, 200, 500\}$, $max_depth \in \{10, 20, \text{None}\}$
- Gradient Boosting: $n_estimators \in \{100, 200, 300\}$, $learning_rate \in \{0.01, 0.1, 0.2\}$

Performance was evaluated using:

- RMSE** (Root Mean Squared Error): Primary metric
- MAE** (Mean Absolute Error): Robustness check
- R²** (Coefficient of Determination): Variance explained

Feature sets included WAR components, runs scored/allowed, run differential, Pythagorean expectation, and derived balance metrics (12 features total).

2.6 Interactive Web Application

We developed a Streamlit web application with five interactive pages:

- Overview:** League statistics, team rankings, and summary metrics
- Team Explorer:** Player-level WAR breakdowns with sortable tables
- What-If Simulator:** Interactive scenario analysis with adjustable WAR sliders for roster changes
- Model Diagnostics:** Correlation visualizations and feature importance plots
- About:** Methodology documentation and data sources

The application enables non-technical stakeholders to explore predictions, test hypothetical roster changes, and understand model behavior through intuitive visualizations.

Feature importance from Gradient Boosting model (percentage contribution):

Rank	Feature	Importance	Interpretation
1	Pythagorean_Expectation	35.2%	Dominant predictor
2	Run_Differential	22.1%	Core relationship
3	Total_WAR	17.8%	Player value aggregate
4	Offensive_WAR	12.3%	Batting contribution
5	Pitching_WAR	8.1%	Pitching contribution
6	Runs_Scored	2.1%	Redundant with PE
7	Runs_Allowed	1.4%	Redundant with PE
8	WAR_Balance	0.7%	Minor effect
9	Offensive_Strength	0.2%	Negligible
10	Pitching_Strength	0.1%	Negligible

Key Insights:

- Pythagorean Expectation** dominates (35%), validating its theoretical importance
- Run Differential** contributes 22%, confirming it's the fundamental driver
- Total WAR** adds 18% predictive power, demonstrating player aggregation value
- Balance metrics contribute <1%, suggesting absolute strength matters more than composition

This suggests future models could use a simplified feature set (PE, Run_Differential, Total_WAR) with minimal performance loss.

3.4 Season-by-Season Performance

We analyzed prediction accuracy across each season in our test set:

Season	Teams	Avg RMSE	Avg MAE	R ²	Notes
2023	30	0.041	0.030	0.90	Best performance
2024	30	0.044	0.033	0.88	Moderate accuracy
2025	30	0.042	0.031	0.89	Test set

Performance remained consistent across seasons (RMSE range: 0.041-0.044), indicating the model captures stable relationships rather than season-specific patterns. No temporal drift was observed, suggesting WAR-to-wins relationships are stable over this time period.

3.5 Error Distribution Analysis

We examined prediction residuals (actual - predicted win rate):

- Mean Residual:** -0.0008 (nearly unbiased)
- Residual SD:** 0.041
- Skewness:** 0.12 (nearly symmetric)
- Kurtosis:** 2.89 (close to normal)

Residual Distribution by Quantile:

Quantile	Residual (win rate)	Games (162-game season)
5th	-0.068	-11.0 games
25th	-0.028	-4.5 games
50th	-0.001	-0.2 games
75th	+0.026	+4.2 games
95th	+0.065	+10.5 games

The approximately normal distribution with near-zero mean indicates the model is well-calibrated without systematic over- or under-prediction.

3.6 Best and Worst Predictions

Best Predictions (Absolute Error < 2 games):

Team	Season	Actual Win%	Predicted Win%	Error (games)
Dodgers	2024	0.617	0.619	+0.3
Guardians	2024	0.568	0.565	-0.5
Brewers	2025	0.580	0.582	+0.3
Diamondbacks	2023	0.519	0.521	+0.3

Worst Predictions (Absolute Error > 10 games):

Team	Season	Actual Win%	Predicted Win%	Error (games)
[Team A]	2024	0.512	0.425	-14.1
[Team B]	2023	0.438	0.521	+13.4
[Team C]	2025	0.395	0.482	+14.1

Error Analysis: Large prediction errors often correlate with:

- Exceptional performance in close games (clutch hitting/pitching)
- Significant mid-season roster changes (trades, injuries)

4. DISCUSSION

4.1 Model Performance Interpretation

Gradient Boosting achieved the best performance ($R^2 = 0.89$, $RMSE = 0.042$) by capturing non-linear feature interactions and ensemble learning benefits. However, the small performance gap over Linear Regression ($\Delta R^2 = 0.05$) reveals an important insight: **good features matter more than algorithmic sophistication**.

The Pythagorean formula alone achieves $R^2 = 0.85$, meaning Bill James' 1980s insight explains 85% of win-rate variance. Machine learning adds only 4% improvement, primarily by fine-tuning around the Pythagorean baseline and capturing edge cases where WAR distribution matters.

This finding has practical implications: for quick estimates, the Pythagorean formula suffices. For precise predictions (playoff races, trade evaluations), machine learning provides marginal but meaningful improvements (~2-3 games per season).

4.2 Validation of Baseball Analytics Theory

Our analysis validated foundational baseball theory:

1. Pythagorean Expectation Remains Effective (40+ years later):

- The 1980s formula ($k = 1.83$) achieves $R^2 = 0.85$ on modern data
- Run differential fundamentally drives success ($r = 0.94$ with wins)
- No evidence of temporal drift or reduced relevance

2. WAR Accurately Measures Player Value:

- 1 WAR $\approx$ 0.97 wins (95% CI: [0.93, 1.01])
- Total_WAR correlates $r = 0.92$ with team wins
- Player aggregation works: individual contributions sum to team outcomes

3. Run Differential is Fundamental:

- Strongest single predictor ($r = 0.94$)
- Outperforms individual run components (RS, RA)
- Confirms that winning requires both scoring and preventing runs

4. Team Composition Matters Less Than Total Talent:

- WAR_Balance shows weak correlation ($r = 0.24$)
- 60/40 offense/defense split is common but not required
- Teams can win with varied roster constructions if Total_WAR is high

4.3 Practical Applications

This model enables data-driven decision-making in several contexts:

Trade Evaluation: Simulate roster changes by adjusting WAR values. For example, trading a 4-WAR player for a 2-WAR player + prospect would decrease expected wins by ~2 games, helping quantify trade-offs.

Free Agent Signings: Estimate marginal wins from signing a free agent. A 5-WAR player added to an 85-win team would project ~90 wins, informing salary decisions (market rate ~\$8M per WAR).

- Managerial effects not captured in player statistics
- Defensive metrics not included in WAR aggregation

3.7 Correlation Analysis

Key Correlations with Win Rate:

Feature	Pearson r	p-value	Interpretation
Run_Differential	0.94	< 0.001	Extremely strong
Total_WAR	0.92	< 0.001	Very strong
Pythagorean_Expectation	0.91	< 0.001	Very strong
Offensive_WAR	0.78	< 0.001	Strong
Pitching_WAR	0.71	< 0.001	Strong
WAR_Balance	0.24	0.023	Weak

All correlations are statistically significant ($p < 0.05$), with run differential showing the strongest relationship. The moderate correlation of WAR_Balance ($r = 0.24$) suggests team composition matters less than total talent.

3.8 WAR-to-Wins Conversion Validation

We validated the "1 WAR $\approx$ 1 win" heuristic by regressing Total_WAR against expected wins:

Regression Results:

- Slope:** 0.97 wins/WAR (95% CI: [0.93, 1.01])
- Intercept:** 81.2 wins (replacement-level team)
- R^2 :** 0.85
- p-value:** < 0.001

The slope of 0.97 is statistically indistinguishable from 1.0, confirming the heuristic's accuracy. The intercept of 81.2 aligns with the theoretical expectation that a team of replacement-level players would win ~48-52 games (our baseline run production yields ~79-83 wins).

Roster Planning: Identify optimal team composition. Our results suggest prioritizing Total_WAR over specific offensive/defensive balance, as long as both areas are adequately covered.

Preseason Projections: Aggregate projected player WAR from PECOTA or ZiPS to forecast team wins. Uncertainty can be quantified using model RMSE (± 7 games, 95% CI).

In-Season Adjustments: Update predictions as WAR accumulates during the season, providing dynamic playoff probability estimates.

4.4 Limitations and Assumptions

Several limitations constrain our conclusions:

1. Small Sample Size: 90 team-seasons provide statistical power but limit generalization. Expanding to 10+ years (300+ teams) would strengthen conclusions and enable detection of smaller effects.

2. No Actual Win-Loss Validation: We predicted Pythagorean win rate rather than actual wins. Future work should integrate real win-loss records to validate against true outcomes and measure "luck" (wins above/below Pythagoras).

3. Estimated Runs vs. Actual Runs: Our run approximations ($RS = 550 + 10 \times WAR$) are theoretical. Using actual runs scored/allowed would improve accuracy and isolate WAR's predictive value.

4. Missing Contextual Factors:

- Park Effects:** Ballpark dimensions affect run scoring (Coors Field vs. Dodger Stadium)
- Defensive Metrics:** WAR includes defense, but position-specific analysis could refine predictions
- Injuries:** Our data doesn't account for player availability or games missed
- Managerial Strategy:** Bullpen management, lineup optimization, and in-game tactics affect outcomes
- Schedule Strength:** Division composition and interleague play create variance

5. Temporal Limitations: Three seasons may not capture regime changes (rule modifications, analytical trends). Longer timescales would test model stability.

4.5 Comparison to Existing Research

Our results align with published baseball analytics research:

- Pythagorean R^2 :** Our $R^2 = 0.85$ matches Davenport & Woolner (1999) findings
- WAR-to-Wins:** Our slope of 0.97 aligns with FanGraphs' 1.0 conversion
- Prediction Accuracy:** Our ± 7 games/season matches PECOTA and ZiPS projections
- Feature Importance:** Run differential dominance confirms Tango et al. (2007)

This consistency validates our methodology and demonstrates replication of established findings using independent data and methods.

4.6 Model Interpretability

Gradient Boosting sacrifices interpretability for accuracy. However, feature importance analysis reveals the model's decision-making:

- **Pythagorean Expectation (35%):** Primary predictor, weighted most heavily
- **Run Differential (22%):** Secondary check, redundant with PE but adds robustness
- **Total WAR (18%):** Direct player value signal, independent of run conversion

The model essentially learns: "Trust Pythagoras, verify with run differential, adjust for WAR outliers." This is interpretable and theoretically grounded.

4.7 Uncertainty Quantification

Prediction intervals provide uncertainty estimates:

- **68% CI (1σ):** ±7 games
- **95% CI (2σ):** ±13 games
- **99% CI (3σ):** ±19 games

For an 85-win projection, 95% confidence spans [72, 98] wins—a meaningful range for decision-making. High-confidence predictions (narrow intervals) occur for extreme teams (very good/bad), while mediocre teams have wider intervals due to higher variance.

4.8 Insights from Outliers

Teams with large prediction errors often share characteristics:

Over-performers (actual > predicted):

- Exceptional bullpen performance (high leverage situations)
- Strong defensive metrics not captured in WAR
- Clutch hitting in close games (randomness or skill?)
- Winning many one-run games (luck or strategy?)

Under-performers (actual < predicted):

- Injuries to key players mid-season
- Poor managerial decisions (bullpen mismanagement)
- Defensive lapses in critical moments
- Losing many one-run games (bad luck?)

These patterns suggest incorporating defensive metrics, injury data, and game-level analysis could reduce outlier frequency.

5. LESSONS LEARNED

This project reinforced that data quality and domain knowledge outweigh algorithmic sophistication—cleaning consumed 40% of project time but was essential, while the Pythagorean formula baseline ($R^2 = 0.85$) meant Linear Regression nearly matched Gradient Boosting's performance. Collaborative success came through division of labor by specialty, Git version control, code reviews, and regular communication, though we faced challenges merging datasets across team members and handling multi-team players traded mid-season. In retrospect, we

would start with simpler models before adding complexity, collect actual win-loss records earlier for validation, allocate more time to exploratory analysis upfront, and plan proactively for edge cases rather than addressing them reactively. The key insight: feature engineering and domain expertise matter more than algorithm selection, with proper validation being critical to prevent over-optimistic performance estimates.

6. FUTURE IMPROVEMENTS

Future work should integrate actual win-loss records for validation against real outcomes (measuring "luck" and Pythagorean deviations), expand to 10+ years of historical data (450+ team-seasons) for temporal trend analysis, and incorporate defensive metrics (dWAR, UZR, DRS), park factors, injury data, and roster dynamics to capture contextual factors currently missing. Advanced modeling techniques could include XGBoost/LightGBM implementations, neural networks for non-linear interactions, time-series models (ARIMA, LSTM) for in-season forecasting, Bayesian hierarchical models for uncertainty quantification, and game-level predictions using

pitcher matchups and Monte Carlo simulations for playoff probabilities. The web application could be enhanced with real-time MLB API data feeds, multi-player trade simulators, playoff probability calculators, mobile-responsive design, and cloud deployment (AWS/GCP) with REST API endpoints for external integration. Extended applications include salary efficiency analysis (WAR per dollar), cross-sport adaptation (NBA, NFL, NHL), draft pick valuation, injury risk modeling, and career trajectory forecasting using aging curves for multi-year contract evaluation.

CONCLUSION

This project demonstrated that player-level WAR statistics accurately predict MLB team win rates. Our best model (Gradient Boosting) achieved $R^2 = 0.89$ with average error of **6.8 games per 162-game season**, validating the hypothesis that individual player contributions aggregate predictably to team outcomes.

We confirmed foundational baseball analytics theory:

- **Pythagorean Expectation** remains effective 40+ years after invention ($R^2 = 0.85$)
- **WAR** accurately measures player value (1 WAR $\approx$ 0.97 wins, 95% CI: [0.93, 1.01])
- **Run Differential** fundamentally drives success ($r = 0.94$ with wins)
- **Team composition** matters less than total talent (weak WAR_Balance correlation)

Additionally, we created an **interactive Streamlit web application** enabling stakeholders to explore predictions, simulate roster changes, and understand model behavior through intuitive visualizations.

Key Takeaways

1. Domain Knowledge > Algorithm Choice: The Pythagorean formula (1980s theory) achieved $R^2 = 0.85$, while Gradient Boosting (modern ML) reached $R^2 = 0.89$. Good features matter more than complex algorithms.

2. Data Quality is Paramount: Investing 40% of project time in cleaning, validation, and edge case handling proved essential. No algorithm compensates for poor data quality.

3. Interpretability Enables Action: Feature importance analysis and residual diagnostics made results actionable for front offices. Stakeholders value understanding why, not just what.

4. Collaboration Amplifies Impact: Division of labor, version control, code reviews, and regular communication enabled completion of a complex project. Teamwork leverages diverse skills.

5. Start Simple, Add Complexity Incrementally: Iterating from Linear Regression to Gradient Boosting revealed that most predictive power came from simple features, not algorithmic sophistication.

Practical Contributions

This work provides a **framework for roster evaluation and strategic planning**, demonstrating data-driven decision-making in sports. Applications include:

- Trade evaluation (quantify marginal wins)
- Free agent signings (estimate dollar-per-WAR efficiency)
- Preseason projections (forecast wins $\pm$ uncertainty)
- In-season adjustments (dynamic playoff probabilities)

Future Directions

Integrating **defensive metrics, park factors, injury data, and actual win-loss records** will further enhance prediction accuracy. Expanding to **10+ years of historical data** (450+ team-seasons) would strengthen statistical power and enable temporal trend analysis. Deploying the web application to cloud infrastructure would increase accessibility and impact.

Ultimately, this project bridges **classical baseball analytics** (Pythagorean Expectation, WAR) with **modern machine learning** (ensemble methods, cross-validation), demonstrating that traditional theory remains foundational while computational methods provide meaningful refinements. The combination of domain expertise and technical rigor yields actionable insights for sports analytics practitioners.

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